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1. Study Courses

To qualify for a residence permit, you must be accepted into one of the following:

- Higher Education: University or University of Applied Sciences (UAS) for a degree.
- Exchange Programs: Between educational institutions.
- Vocational Education: Leading to a qualification.
- Other Studies: Only if there is a "justified reason" (e.g., further training or specialized professional studies). Language courses alone usually do not qualify unless they are part of a degree path.

2. Embassy Appointment

After submitting your application online via the Enter Finland portal, you must visit a Finnish embassy, consulate, or a **VFS Global application center** to verify your identity and provide biometrics (fingerprints).

Correction (source: migri.fi): According to Migri, applicants must visit a Finnish mission (embassy or consulate). Migri does not route study residence permit applicants through VFS Global. The appointment booking system used is migri.vihta.com (the Finnish Immigration Service booking portal).

How to book: You book the appointment through the **Finland Visa/Residence Permit website (VFS Global)** or directly through the embassy's appointment system if VFS is not available in your country.

Correction (source: migri.fi): Appointments are booked directly through the Finnish mission's own system at migri.vihta.com. There is no VFS Global routing for Finnish study residence permit applications.

3. Applying for a Study Visa (Residence Permit)

The Steps:

1. Acceptance: Receive an official letter of acceptance from a Finnish school.
2. Online Application: Create an account on Enter Finland.
3. Payment: Pay the processing fee (**€350 online / €450 paper**).
Correction (source: migri.fi, 2026 fee schedule): The correct fees for a first residence permit for studies are €600 (electronic application) / €750 (paper application).
4. Verification: Visit the embassy/VFS center to prove your identity.
5. Decision: Wait for the decision (you can track this in Enter Finland).
6. Permit Card: If approved, your residence permit card is mailed to the embassy or your home (depending on the location).

How long it takes:

- Electronic applications: 1-2 months on average.
- Peak season (July-August) may take longer.

4. Documents Needed

- Valid Passport.
- Certificate of Acceptance: From a Finnish educational institution.
- Proof of Funds: Bank statements showing you have the required money.
- Insurance: A policy covering medical and pharmaceutical expenses (e.g., Swisscare or SIP).
- Tuition Fee Receipt: Proof that you have paid the first-year fee (or proof of scholarship).
- Previous Certificates: If you are a minor or a vocational student.

5. Money Requirements

You must prove you have at least €560 per month available for your use.

- For a one-year permit: €6,720.
- The money must be in your own bank account (parents' bank statements are generally not accepted unless the money is transferred to you).
- If your school provides free room and board, the required amount is lower.

6. Residence Permit Post-Arrival

Unlike many countries, Finland issues the residence permit before you arrive.

- Once you arrive: You do not need to "apply" for the permit again. However, you must visit the Digital and Population Data Services Agency (DVV) to register your place of residence and receive a Finnish personal identity code (if you didn't get one with your permit).

7. Working While Studying

- Allowed: Yes.
- Hours: You can work for an average of 30 hours per week during the academic term.
- **Holidays: During breaks (Summer/Christmas), there is no hour limit.**
- **Correction (source: migri.fi): There is no unlimited period. The 30-hour limit is an annual average. During holiday periods students may work more than 30 hours per week, but the total average across the full year must still not exceed 30 hours per week (i.e., no more than 1,560 hours per year).**

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

If your studies continue beyond the expiration of your first permit (usually 1 or 2 years):

- Apply for an Extended Permit via Enter Finland.
- Requirement: You must show progress in your studies (at least 45 ECTS credits per academic year).
- Apply before your current permit expires.

9. Changing to a Work Permit

After graduation, you have two main options:

1. 1. Post-study Permit (Job Seeking): You can apply for a residence permit to look for work or start a business. This is valid for up to two years and can be taken in parts.
2. 2. Work-based Permit: Once you find a job, you apply for a residence permit "based on work." Since you have a Finnish degree, the "labor market testing" (checking if a Finn could do the job) is waived.

10. Official Information

- Finnish Immigration Service (Migri): migri.fi/en/studying-in-finland
- Study in Finland: studyinfinland.fi
- Ministry for Foreign Affairs: um.fi
- InfoFinland: infofinland.fi

11. Application Forms

- Online (Preferred): Enter Finland
- Paper Forms: If you cannot apply online, forms (Form OLE_OPI) can be downloaded from the Migri Application Forms page.

12. Tips for Students (Common Mistakes)

- Insufficient Insurance: Ensure your insurance has a deductible of no more than €300 and covers the entire duration of your stay.
- Late Application: Apply as soon as you get your acceptance letter. July is extremely busy.
- Incomplete Funds: Make sure the €6,720 is in your account. A letter of support from a relative is usually not enough; the cash must be accessible to you.
- Slow Progress: If you don't earn enough credits (45 ECTS), your renewal might be rejected.
- Passport Validity: Ensure your passport is valid for the entire period you are applying for.

1. Study Courses Eligible for a Study Visa

You may apply for a residence permit for studies if you have been accepted as a student at a higher education institution or other educational institution in Finland, and your studies will lead to a degree or a vocational qualification. Eligible institutions include universities, universities of applied sciences, and vocational education institutions.

If your studies do not lead to a degree or vocational qualification, a residence permit may still be granted if there are reasonable grounds, such as further training to supplement existing qualifications, training related to work done in your home country, or special training available only in Finland.

A residence permit cannot be granted if your studies mainly consist of online distance learning that does not require your physical presence in Finland.

Two visa categories exist:

- Schengen (short-stay) visa — for courses under 90 days, such as short courses, seminars, language courses, or single university modules
- Residence permit for studies — for any program lasting more than 90 days

2. Booking an Embassy Appointment

After submitting your application online through the Enter Finland portal, you must book and attend an appointment at the nearest Finnish embassy or consulate for identity verification.

- **Appointments at Finnish embassies and consulates are booked through the Finnish Ministry for Foreign Affairs website: um.fi**
- **Correction:** In most countries, identity-verification and biometric appointments at Finnish missions abroad are booked through VFS Global, the outsourced visa and residence permit application centre, with country-specific instructions listed on finlandabroad.fi (part of the Ministry for Foreign Affairs' site network). um.fi itself does not provide a direct appointment-booking system. (Sources: migri.fi, finlandabroad.fi)
- For service point appointments inside Finland: migri.vihta.com
- Contact the Finnish embassy or consulate in your country of residence directly, as procedures may vary by location

3. Applying for a Study Visa — Step by Step

How to apply:

- Start by reading Migri's Guide for Students at migri.fi — it contains tailored instructions and lets you compile a personalised checklist
- Apply through the Enter Finland portal at enterfinland.fi with all required documents
- After submitting your application online, book and attend an appointment at the nearest Finnish embassy or consulate for identity verification
- You can also apply for a D visa at the same time as your residence permit. The D visa allows you to travel to Finland immediately after being issued a residence permit, during a window of 100 days before the permit becomes valid

Processing time:

Processing typically takes 2–4 weeks for online applications, but can extend to 1–3 months during peak seasons or for complex cases

Fees:

The application fee is 470 EUR for an online application or 500 EUR for a paper application for the first residence permit for studies.

Correction: As of 1 January 2026, the official Migri processing fee for a first residence permit for studies is EUR 600 for an online application and EUR 750 for a paper application (up from EUR 450 / EUR 550 in 2025). Fees are revised annually by decree of the Ministry of the Interior, so the current figure should always be checked on migri.fi before paying. (Sources: migri.fi, intermin.fi)

4. Documents Needed

- Valid passport from your country of nationality
- Acceptance letter from a Finnish educational institution confirming admission to a degree or qualification program
- Proof of sufficient financial means (see Section 5)
- Proof of health insurance valid for the entire duration of your stay
- Two recent passport-sized photographs meeting Finnish visa specifications
- **Correction:** Migri requires only one passport photo (or a digital photo retrieval code from a photo shop) that is no more than 6 months old — not two photographs. (Source: migri.fi)
- Academic transcripts from all previous educational institutions
- Proof of payment of tuition fees, if applicable

All attachments must be translated and legalised where necessary before submission

For doctoral or postgraduate research: if you come to Finland for postgraduate studies after completing a master's degree, you need to apply for a residence permit for scientific research rather than a standard study permit

5. Money Requirements

- You must have at least 800 EUR per month at your disposal to cover accommodation, food, and other needs
- You must have 9,600 EUR in your bank account at the time of submitting your application, covering the first year
- If your studies take less than one year, you must have 800 EUR available for each month of your stay
- If you will pay tuition fees at a later stage, the full tuition fee amount must also be present in your bank account at the time of application
- Acceptable proof includes bank statements, scholarship letters, or a signed sponsor declaration

6. Residence Permit After Arriving in Finland

- If you come to Finland to complete a higher education degree, you can be granted a continuous (A) residence permit and will receive a municipality of residence. If you come to study for some other qualification, you may receive a temporary (B) residence permit
- Collect your residence permit card from a designated collection point in Finland
- Visit a service location of the Digital and Population Data Services Agency (dvv.fi) in person if you were not issued a personal identity code with your card, to register your personal details in the Population Information System

7. Working While Studying

- A student with a residence permit for studies is allowed to work in paid employment in any field for an average of 30 hours per week
- The weekly limit can be exceeded in some weeks, as long as the annual average does not surpass 30 hours per week — equivalent to approximately 120 hours per month or 1,560 hours per year
- During holidays, students are allowed to work full-time, provided the annual average stays within the 30-hour limit
- The 30-hour limit does not apply to diploma work or internships that are formally part of the degree program

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

- If you have not graduated in the expected time, you may be granted an extended permit to complete your studies, for the duration of your remaining right to study
- You may be refused renewal if you do not make sufficient academic progress — you must complete at least 45 credits per academic year. If you have completed fewer, you must submit a statement explaining the reasons
- Apply using the same form as for the first permit, through Enter Finland or on paper. After submitting, visit a Finnish Immigration Service point to prove your identity and have your fingerprints taken
- Extended permits can only be applied for while you are inside Finland

9. Changing to a Work Permit After Graduation

- After graduation, you can apply for a residence permit based on a degree completed in Finland, if you have a job, pursue a trade, or engage in business activities in Finland
- You can also apply for a permit to look for work or to start a business if you have or previously had a residence permit for studies. This permit can be used in three parts, each of at least six months, with the last part ending within three years of when the first part started
- Permanent residence is possible after four years on a continuous residence permit, including your study period, especially if you are employed post-graduation

10. Official Government Websites

- Finnish Immigration Service (Migri): migri.fi/en
- Online application portal: enterfinland.fi
- Study in Finland (official): studyinfinland.fi
- Finnish Ministry for Foreign Affairs (visas): um.fi
- Digital and Population Data Services Agency: dvv.fi
- Appointment booking: migri.vihta.com
- Processing time checker: migri.fi/en/check-the-processing-time

11. Application Forms

- Online applications (recommended): enterfinland.fi — guides you through the full process step by step
- Applying online costs less than a paper application, and if you used strong electronic identification, you may not need to visit a service point when renewing
- Paper application form: available to download at migri.fi/en/residence-permit-application-for-studies
- Schengen short-stay visa forms: available at um.fi

12. Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

- Applying too late — once admitted to a Finnish institution, start your residence permit application as soon as possible to ensure you receive your permit before the start of your studies
- Insufficient funds at the time of application — the full 9,600 EUR must be in your bank account when you submit, not just planned for the future
- Submitting a first permit application from inside Finland — as of 1 September 2024, an application for a first residence permit must be submitted outside Finland; applying from inside Finland will generally result in a negative decision
- Applying for the wrong visa type — if your course is entirely online and requires no physical presence in Finland, a study residence permit will be refused
- Missing or untranslated documents — attachments must be translated and legalised where necessary; failing to do so causes delays or rejections
- Insufficient academic progress for renewal — you must complete at least 45 credits per academic year to qualify for permit renewal; track your progress throughout your studies
- Using paid consultancy unnecessarily — you do not need to use fee-based consultancy services, as Enter Finland guides you through the entire process

Always verify the latest requirements directly on migri.fi, as Finnish immigration rules are subject to change.